Countersign QA Report

First-time-user QA of the Countersign hub and shared Arc Studio demos. Testnet only. No funds moved, no transactions signed, no account created, no wallet extension installed.

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Verdict

No — not self-explanatory enough for a stranger's first impression today.

A. Verdict

A stranger can open https://web-production-a58de.up.railway.app, read the escrow/agent-payments pitch, and browse Registry, Assistant, Seller, Merchant, Start, and Verify without an account. I could not complete or validate a first purchase under the access available for this test: no real email for Privy OTP, no existing passkey, and no connected wallet. A stranger who already has a wallet (or completes email/passkey) may be able to buy — that path was not tested. Sign-in stopped at Privy's "Log in or sign up" (email placeholder your@email.com, Submit, Continue with a wallet, I have a passkey); fixed code

123456 was not used because no test-code indication appeared and the code-delivery stage was not reached. No wallet UI appeared; do not treat hub default buyer 0xE062… as a connected wallet. Buyer “phone” asks for an Approval token with no in-product explanation of how a first-time user obtains an envelope or token. Pre-sign terms on Assistant were clear (0.01 USDC; seller 0x6BE98051B852824A3923E3B27f9781Ceb0C0ca4a; Arc escrow / Arc testnet; 2 min then anyone can refund — not automatic). Hero “3 rails live” vs Registry’s five rail filters is a first-impression scope inconsistency. Shared Arc Studio / Vercel demos open without sign-in but present an unlabeled ready sample and degraded ledger sync. Verifier correctly validates a reachable slip and rejects a doubled amount; a true offline/disconnected run was not performed. Net: first impression fails on onboarding clarity and rail-scope messaging even though browse + verify largely work.

B. Step / surface table

Step / surface	Result	One-line evidence
1. First 10s impression	Blocked / limited	Clean first-ten-seconds requirement not met: first load was not clean-profile; Incognito only after phase 1.
2a. Landing	Fail	Hero shows “3 rails live”; Registry lists five rail filters — scope inconsistency.
2b. Registry	Pass*	Renders 5 sellers · 10 offers · 4 online; search + rail filter exercised. *Render/browse pass — not every control exhaustively verified.
2c. Offer detail	Pass*	Price/rail/deadline/schemas shown; seller “unnamed” + address. *Page render + content audit.
2d. Assistant	Pass*	Search matches; purchase card states amount/payee/rail/deadline; Hold succeeds on true ≥2s press.
2e. Verify	Pass	Newest slip VALID; doubled-amount INVALID;

		chain read shows Released @ block 71,069,395.
2f. Seller	Pass*	0x6BE9… desk shows 0.22 USDC / 22 released / 0 refunded. *Hub-reported figures.
2g. Buyer	Fail	Onboarding usability: Approval token required with no acquisition path for a first-time user. Token gate itself not shown faulty.
2h. Merchant / Start	Pass*	Merchant “Whose ledger?” form; Start wallet/sell/buy chooser. *Surfaces rendered; deep ledger open not fully exercised.
3. Sign in	Blocked	Privy email / wallet / passkey. No email supplied; OTP stage not reached; 123456 unused.
4. Wallet address/chain	Not observed / blocked	No wallet UI appeared. Address and chain unobserved. Hub buyer 0xE062… is not a session wallet.
5. Purchase to signing	Blocked	Pre-sign purchase card reviewed (amount/seller/rail/deadline). Actual signing boundary not reached.
6. Refund/deadline vs rail	Pass	No confirmed false direct-rail auto-refund claim on inspected escrow terms.
7. Receipt + verifier	Pass	Reachable verify URL without paying; VALID and INVALID outputs recorded. Offline disconnect not tested.
8a. studio.arc.io share	Pass	Opens without sign-in. Community disclaimer; Open app → Vercel.
8b. Vercel escrow console	Fail	Opens without sign-in. Unlabeled ready

		sample + empty seller + changing nash; separate sync/RPC lag.

As of 2026-11-07 Asia/Calcutta. Pass = exercised within stated scope; Fail = defect; Blocked = access/policy stop.

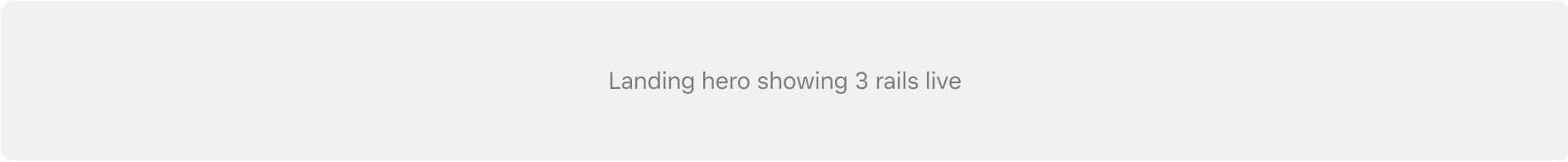
C. Ranked defects

One finding per defect. Ranked by damage to a first impression.

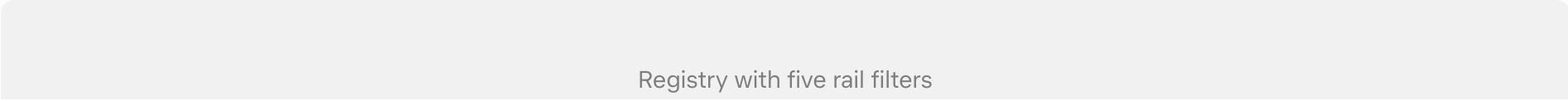
C1. Rail-scope inconsistency on first screens

Severity	● High — first screen vs next screen
URL	https://web-production-a58de.up.railway.app/ · https://web-production-a58de.up.railway.app/#/registry
Repro	Open landing; read hero stats. Open Registry; read the rail filter row.
Expected	Consistent rail messaging a stranger can trust.
Actual	Hero: “3 rails live”. Registry filters list Arc·escrow, Hedera·scheduled, Hedera·x402, Whitechain·USDT, Arc·Gateway (five). Hub prose also emphasizes a narrower declared set (escrow, whitechain, hedera-scheduled). Treat as scope ambiguity / inconsistent messaging — not automatic proof that listed rails lack settlement.
Console	None for this UI contradiction.
Fix	Align hero count, Registry filters, and declared rails under one labeled taxonomy (live vs listed vs discovery).

Landing hero capture shows “3 rails live” only — not the five-rail list. Registry capture shows the five filters. Pair required.



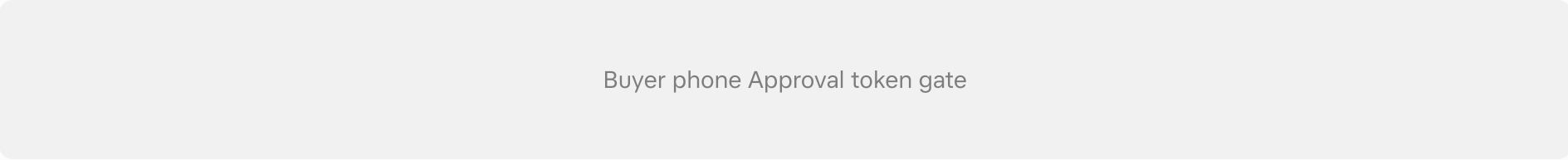
Landing — visible: 3 rails live only.



Registry — visible: five rail filters.

C2. Buyer onboarding: Approval token with no acquisition path

Severity	● High — first-time human path
URL	https://web-production-a58de.up.railway.app/#/buyer
Repro	Open Buyer. Leave Approval token empty. Activate Use this token.
Expected	Explain envelope + how to obtain an approval token, or offer a bootstrap.
Actual	“Paste the token first.” Onboarding usability failure for a stranger. The token gate itself was not shown to be broken — there is simply no first-time acquisition path on this surface.
Console	Unauthenticated hub 401s on envelopes/approvals for default buyer address — expected without a token; not a separate ranked UI bug.
Fix	Document and link envelope creation and approval-token issuance from the Buyer phone empty state.

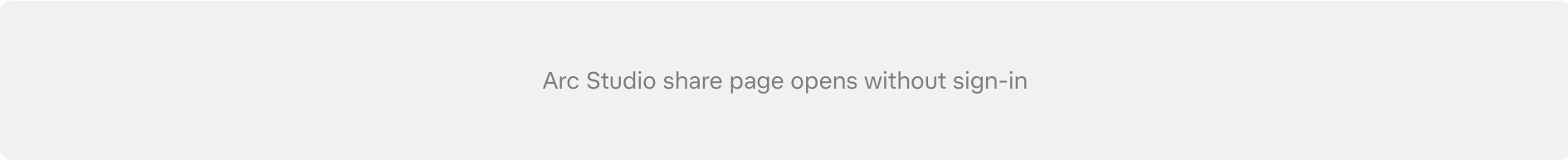


Buyer — token required; no acquisition path shown.

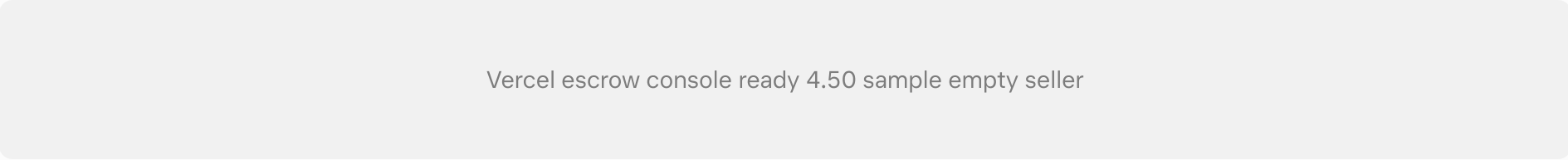
C3. Shared demo: unlabeled ready sample, empty seller, changing offer hash

Severity	● High on shared demo URLs
URL	https://studio.arc.io/share/countersign-automated-software-marketplace-9tfb9kfte9 → https://arc-studio-16e0b317ec5f406a8d7d24bf.vercel.app/
Repro	Open share without sign-in; open app; note Offer pane and hash across reloads.
Expected	Labeled demo sample; stable offer identity; named seller or clear “enter seller”.
Actual	Ready “Extract line items from a PDF invoice” at 4.50 USDC, seller bond 1.00, Open deadline, seller address empty, Connect

	wallet. Offer hash changes across loads — unlabeled regenerated example; not evidence of a pinned published offer, and not framed as fraud.
Console	Not required for this finding (RPC covered in C5).
Fix	Label the sample as Demo, pin one offer hash, and require or prefill a named seller address.



studio.arc.io share — public, Community disclaimer.



Vercel console — ready sample, empty seller (also shows ledger lag used in C5).

C4. Unnamed sellers on hub offers (usability)

Severity	● Medium — browse trust / usability
URL	https://web-production-a58de.up.railway.app/#/registry and offer pages
Repro	Open Registry or an offer detail.
Expected	Display name or an explicit “anonymous by design” label.
Actual	“Unnamed seller” + hex address on cards and offers. Usability / attribution issue — not a security proof that sellers are malicious or fake.
Console	None.
Fix	Require a display name on publish, or state anonymity as intentional product policy on every card.

Offer with unnamed seller attribution

Offer — unnamed seller (usability).

C5. Demo ledger sync lag / Arc RPC 429s

Severity	Medium — demo credibility
URL	https://arc-studio-16e0b317ec5f406a8d7d24bf.vercel.app/
Repro	Open console; watch Ledger status; observe rpc.testnet.arc.io failures.
Expected	Near tip, or clear “catching up / cached demo” copy.
Actual	Ledger recovered from ~30,201 blocks behind to 2,201 behind — degraded sync, not a permanent outage. Concurrent HTTP 429 responses from https://rpc.testnet.arc.io/.
Console	ERROR 429 @ https://rpc.testnet.arc.io/ (repeated).
Fix	Cache or back off Arc testnet RPC and show last synced block while catching up.

Vercel ledger Syncing 2201 blocks behind

Same console capture — Ledger “Syncing, 2201 blocks behind”.

D. Claims observed that are not fully backed

Scope ambiguity (not proven false)

> Hero “3 rails live” vs Registry five-rail list vs narrower hub emphasis (escrow / whitechain / hedera-scheduled): inconsistent messaging. The narrower set may be “declared settlement capability” while Registry lists discovery rails — ambiguity, not automatic proof of nonexistent settlement on the extra rails.

Global “payments that only move when the work lands” is broader than what direct rails imply; treat as scope ambiguity unless each rail’s settlement model is spelled out. Not independently proven false in this pass.

Unverified / hub-reported only

“Every payment here was real” — environment is testnet; only one Arc escrow settlement was chain-checked in Verify (Released at block 71,069,395). Not a mainnet reality claim and not a full audit of every counter.

“Every figure read from the hub” / live job and USDC counters — hub-reported; counter movement is not proof every listed settlement completed as claimed.

Seller delivery % and refund counts — hub-reported; not independently recomputed on-chain here.

“43 Foundry tests” (and similar contract-marketing claims) — not checked.

Known contract limit “One blocked payee freezes every payout” — disclosed / accepted known limitation; not independently audited in this QA.

Merchant /merchant-api/me HTTP 503 — seen in original session diagnostics only; Merchant page screenshot is the form, not an error page. Unverified as a ranked product bug.

Unauthenticated hub 401s on envelopes/approvals — expected without credentials; not automatically a defect.

Withdrawn / not confirmed

False direct-rail automatic refund claim — not confirmed on inspected escrow terms (“anyone can refund” after deadline).

Hold control permanently broken — false; succeeds on a true ≥2s press.

Buyer tabs broken — not confirmed; surface is token-gated.

Changing demo offer hash proves a fake published offer — not established; fits an unlabeled regenerated local sample.

E. Missing in the first two minutes

1. Plain explanation of envelope + approval token: what they are, who creates them, and how a first-time human gets a token

1. Plain explanation of envelope + approval token: what they are, who creates them, and how a first-time human gets a token onto the Buyer phone.
2. Who can trigger a refund, on which rail, and when (deadline actor — not only “2 min”).
3. One consistent map of live vs listed vs declared rails.
4. Seller display names or an explicit anonymity policy.
5. Demo labeling on Arc Studio / Vercel so a ready 4.50 sample is not read as a live marketplace listing.
6. A short “what happens to the money” strip tying amount, rail, deadline, refund actor, and slip — without requiring a wallet-less purchase path as a product mandate.

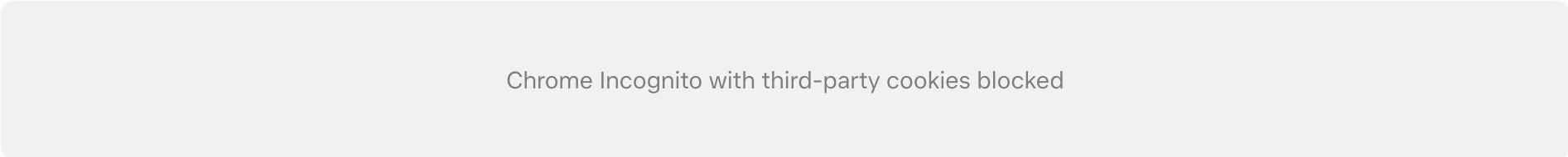
Method and caveats

Hub under test: https://web-production-a58de.up.railway.app. Testnet only. No funds moved. No transactions signed. No spending approved. No account created. No wallet extension installed.

> The big headline is “payments that only move when the work lands.” I took it for a tool-marketplace or payments site for AI agents, with escrow. It was not obvious who it was for or what to click. I would have clicked “Ask for a paid tool.”
>
> Initial impression — original phase-1 context (not Incognito)

⚠ Profile caveat

That first impression is from the original (non-clean) session. True Chrome Incognito (Ctrl+Shift+N) was opened only afterward; third-party cookies were blocked there. Core surfaces were retested in Incognito; the clean first-ten-seconds requirement was not satisfied on the first load.



Incognito after phase 1 — third-party cookies blocked.

Phase-1 landing hero

Phase-1 landing (original context) — 3 rails live.

Full screen audit

Landing

Claims escrow-held agent payments and verifiable slips. Shows live counters and “3 rails live”. Controls: Ask for a paid tool, live desk, Sign in. Deep live-desk path not fully exercised.

Registry

Renders sellers/offers and five rail filters. Search empty-state and a rail filter were exercised. Pass is render + those controls — not a claim that every Registry function was verified.

Registry listing

Registry listing.

Registry search no matches

Search empty-state.

Offer detail

use-arc: 0.01 USDC, Arc·escrow, 2 min deadline, schemas + CLI/curl. Hedera Agent Kit offer also reviewed (unnamed seller).

use-arc offer

Offer — use-arc.

Assistant

Search and purchase card reviewed. Hold on a true ≥2s press reveals the agent command (success capture below). Signing not attempted.

Assistant purchase card

Assistant pre-sign card.

Assistant after successful Hold showing agent CLI command

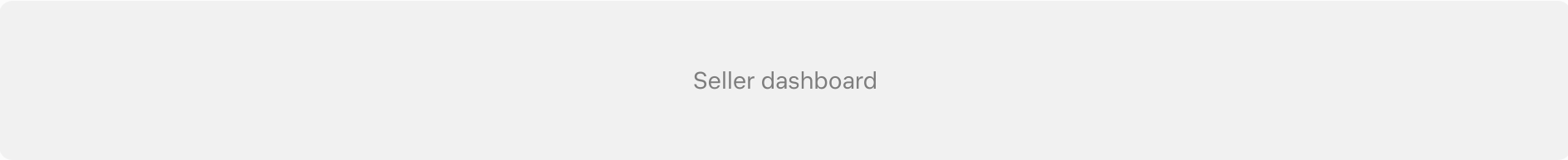
Hold success — agent CLI command revealed.

Verify

See Verifier section for exact observed UI wording and full IDs.

Seller

Seller desk for 0x6BE9… shows earnings and Released sales (hub-reported).



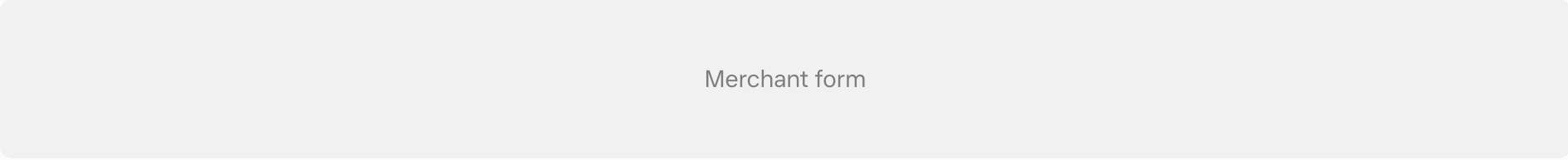
Seller desk (Incognito retest).

Buyer

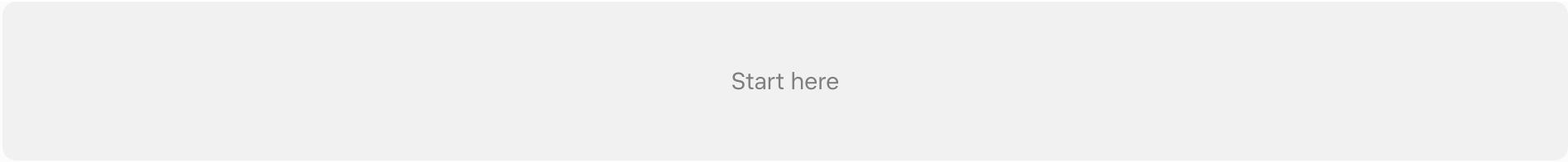
Approval-token onboarding wall. Gate not proven faulty; acquisition path missing.

Merchant / Start

Merchant ledger picker and Start here intents render.



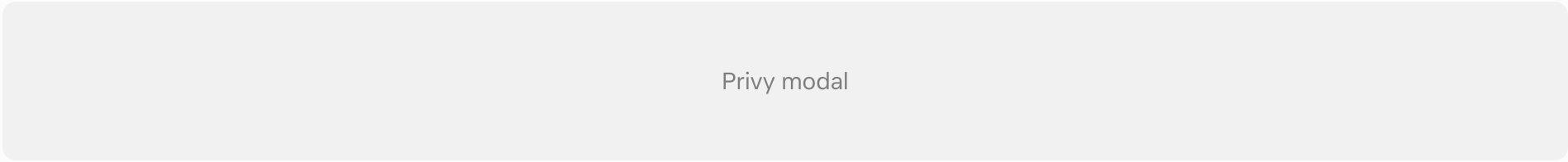
Merchant.



Start here.

Sign-in (blocked)

Privy “Log in or sign up”; your@email.com; Submit; Continue with a wallet; I have a passkey. Stopped here.



Sign-in blocked at Privy.

Verifier prints

Offline / disconnect

The product states checks run in the browser. A real disconnected (offline) test was not conducted. Signature validity and chain-checked Released are reported separately.

Verified slip (full verify URL)
web-production-a58de.up.railway.app

Slip / verify id	0xff8976e41eee194a0294be88d394e356f20dbfe243386b3c5b1b9212ee8eb2a9
Transaction	0x3ce0d4341797435ded37b5ad6e9b437404e590033def483b3dd902dc65a67e1e

Seller	0x6BE98051B852824A3923E3B27f9781Ceb0C0ca4a
network / chainId	eip155:5042002 (Arc testnet)
rail	escrow
amount (valid body)	10000

Before chain — observed UI

Exact observed headings/body from the browser:

> VALID. Hash and signatures checked in this browser. Nothing was sent anywhere and the chain was not asked.

The hash commits to every field.

Keccak-256 of the body in canonical JSON is the slip hash, so no field has changed.

Signed by the seller.

EIP-712 Release(jobId, slipHash), under the escrow contract’s own domain.

The buyer agreed to this offer, payee and amount.

The countersigned terms derive this slip’s job id.

Countersigned by the buyer.

One EIP-3009 signature names the escrow and binds the amount and the job.

Settlement not read from the chain.

The slip names the transaction below. Read it from Arc testnet here, or open it on the explorer.

After Check the chain — observed UI

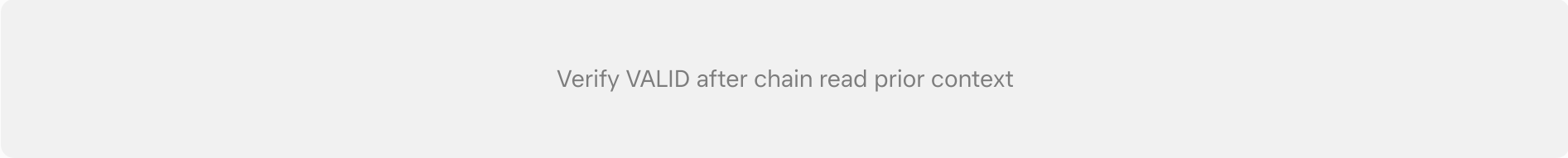
> VALID. Hash and signatures checked in this browser. The release was read from Arc testnet’s public RPC.

First four checks unchanged from before-chain. Additional observed lines:

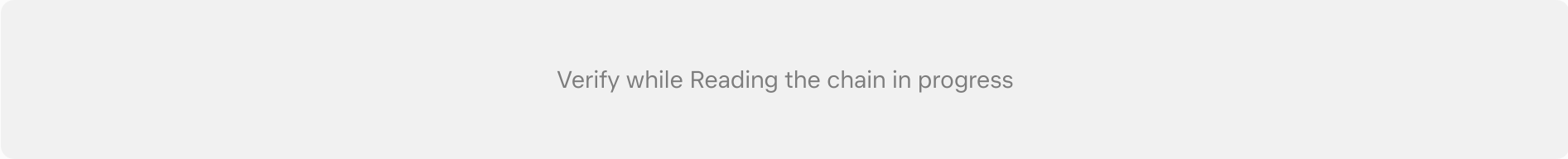
Known escrow: Arc testnet, deployed through Arc Studio.

The chain holds this slip’s hash.

Arc testnet block 71,069,395: the escrow’s Released event for this job carries exactly the hash computed here.



After chain — prior-context capture (not Incognito).



Capture during “Reading the chain” (in progress), not a pure before-chain idle state.

Tampered amount — observed UI

Helper: “The same slip with its amount doubled after signing.” Amount 10000 → 20000.

> INVALID

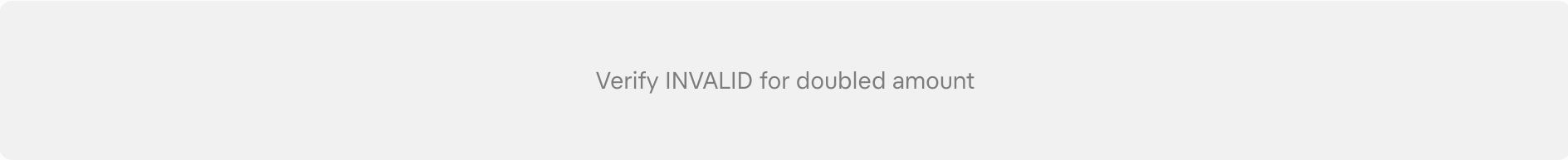
Exact observed failure lines (ellipses are UI abbreviations, not full hashes):

Body hashes to 0x1782…b444, slip says 0xff89…b2a9.

Signed by 0x92c5…064F, not the seller 0x6BE9…ca4a.

The countersigned terms differ from the slip.

Buyer EIP-3009 check still passed independently. Settlement was not read from the chain on this tampered run. (Ellipses above are as shown in the UI.)



INVALID — doubled amount helper; ellipses as in UI.

External demos

1. Arc Studio share — Countersign Automated Software Marketplace
   studio.arc.io
2. Countersign escrow console (Vercel)
   arc-studio-16e0b317ec5f406a8d7d24bf.vercel.app

studio.arc.io share · Opens

Opens without sign-in. Community app notice: Circle has not reviewed or endorsed. Open app links to the Vercel console.

Vercel escrow console · Opens / flawed

Opens without sign-in. Ready 4.50 USDC sample, empty seller, changing hash (C3). Ledger sync lag + RPC 429 (C5). Connect wallet not exercised (no extension / no spend).

Full URLs: https://studio.arc.io/share/countersign-automated-software-marketplace-9tfb9kfte9 and https://arc-studio-16e0b317ec5f406a8d7d24bf.vercel.app/

Evidence appendix

- [x] ~~No funds moved / no tx signed / no spend approved~~